

SOLID START FOR MCLAREN

Lando Norris and Oscar Piastri bag **top honours** in the first two races, as Lewis Hamilton 'sprints' a surprise.



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Two consecutive, action-packed race weekends were the perfect way to start the new and highly awaited Formula One season.

Australia and China had the prized opportunity to reveal what's in store for the 2025 calendar, ending a nearly three-month-long wait.

Among the 20 names that lined up on the Albert Park grid were a few new ones, and the Australian Grand Prix provided the perfect stage for a stellar introduction. The paddock went back Down Under for the curtain-raiser, and Melbourne welcomed them with plenty of showers.

It was one of the greatest tests of strategy and skill. With the weather and rain proving difficult to predict, teams and drivers had to nail tough calls, tyres, and timings to be the best of the rest. And it was Lando Norris who prevailed, giving McLaren a boost to its title defence campaign.

Off the mark

The domination from defending champion McLaren was one that most expected, considering the high it ended on last year and strong performances in pre-season testing. The fact that McLaren had the same driver duo from last season meant that good communication — the key to cracking tough races — was ever-present.

Norris, last year's runner-up, ensured mistakes of the past would not haunt him, acing the strategy calls and a difficult drive to claim the first win of the year. The 57-lap encounter had crashes and Safety Cars galore, but the Briton battled through, even keeping a charging Max Verstappen behind, a bonus to a hard-fought victory.

It was only towards the closing stages that the championship holder Verstappen caught up to his rival. Up until lap 44, McLaren looked on course for a 1-2 finish, with the hometown favourite Oscar Piastri closely following his teammate. But once the rain set in, the hearts of the Australian faithful sank as he spun and tumbled down the order.

Flawless: The defending constructors champion got off to a flying start with a double-podium finish in Australia and China.

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